DAILY READING • 样张

# The Plaster Saint

2026-11-08 · 当天 50 词全部覆盖 · 全文 644 词 · 5 段

短文

My aunt Ruth bought the Seabreak Motel the spring I turned eleven, because the price was low and the view was not. The building stood where the road ran straight into the tide, so the water came up under the stilts twice a day. Half of the rooms smelled of wet wood and slow decay, and the brass numbers had gone green. Ruth said the brown stain above room four would pass, but it looked permanent to me. A small sensor above the office door chimed six times on an average afternoon. Those six cars belonged to her loyal ones, she said, and the budget in her blue notebook promised forty a night by peak season. The glass float in the window was the only ornament she could afford.

Every morning Ruth memorized the tide table from the radio and wrote the times on her wrist. The weather man could predict a squall four hours early, and on Tuesday he promised one by evening. Ruth took the usual precautions, which meant sandbags at the office door and the float moved higher. A young man from the harbour office came by to inform her that the tents would move to the hard standing. I tried to overhear what they said about money, but Ruth has a temper that carries and a voice that does not. She is tolerant of my questions, though, and sincere in a way that makes adults look at their shoes. She did not deny that she was worried, and shortly after six the rain came sideways.

The procession is older than anyone remembers, and the town charter still names the three families whose job it is to carry the plaster saint down to the water. This year the council appointed Ruth, which pleased her more than she was willing to admit. Four men from the fish market came at noon to elevate the statue onto the back of a flatbed truck. The flagpole mechanism on the pier had seized, so a temporary crank was fitted by a man who called the era of iron boats a waste of paint. A section of the railing was roped off, and nobody argued about the necessity of it. The gravity of the occasion made everyone speak in low voices, even the children who did not understand it.

By Thursday the town smelled of vinegar and dye, because every flag for the procession had to be dipped by hand in the shed behind the fish market. The rooms of the motel stand in a linear row along the shore, which is why the superior ones at the far end sell last. Ruth had ordered three tins of red dye and received one, and the scarcity turned a simple job into a complex argument about which flags could go without. She paid compensation to a commercial photographer who had booked the front rooms for a shoot, and the loss meant the week would not exceed last year's takings. Her bookkeeping stayed consistent, and the export crates of salted fish went out on Friday as usual.

On Saturday the newspaper on the counter carried a headline about a terrorist arrested two towns away, and by nine three guests had asked if the procession was safe. Ruth is witty when she is frightened, so she said a man with a bad plan would find our flags the least attractive target in the county. I was too thirsty to laugh, and I could not perceive any fear in her voice, which I think was the intent. Her short speech seemed to convey more than the words did, and the ultimate decision was to go ahead. The crowd on the pier grew long enough to compel the council to reopen the railing. Takings went downward again in the last week of August, but the loyalty of those six regulars held.

解析 · 行间留白，可直接手写

My aunt Ruth bought the Seabreak Motel the spring I turned eleven, because the price was low and the view was not. The building stood where the road ran straight into the tide, so the water came up under the stilts twice a day. Half of the rooms smelled of wet wood and **slow decay**, and the brass numbers had gone green. Ruth said the brown stain above room four would pass, but it looked permanent to me. A small sensor above the office door chimed six times **on an average afternoon**. Those six cars belonged to her loyal ones, she said, and the budget in her blue notebook promised forty a night **by peak season**. The glass float in the window was the only ornament she could afford.

> **slow decay** 缓慢的腐朽 decay 作名词指建筑、木材等渐进的朽坏；常与 slow / gradual / tooth 连用，不说 fast decay
> **on an average afternoon** 在一个普通的下午 average 作形容词表示“平常的、一般的”，与 ordinary 近义；on an average day / afternoon 是常见搭配
> **by peak season** 到旺季时 peak 修饰季节、时段表示最高峰；介词用 by 表“到……时为止”，不用 in peak season 表“到”

Every morning Ruth **memorized the tide table** from the radio and wrote the times on her wrist. The weather man could predict a squall four hours early, and on Tuesday he promised one by evening. Ruth **took the usual precautions**, which meant sandbags at the office door and the float moved higher. A young man from the harbour office came by to inform her that the tents would move to the hard standing. I tried to overhear what they said about money, but Ruth has a temper that carries and a voice that does not. She is tolerant of my questions, though, and sincere in a way that makes adults look at their shoes. She **did not deny that** she was worried, and shortly after six the rain came sideways.

> **memorized the tide table** 背下了潮汐表 memorize 强调“记牢、背下”，宾语多为 list / table / line 等需逐条记住的内容，比 remember 更主动
>
> **took the usual precautions** 采取了惯常的预防措施 precaution 常用复数；搭配 take precautions against sth，against 后接风险来源，不能接动作
>
> **did not deny that** 没有否认…… deny 后接 that 从句或动名词，不接 to do；deny doing sth 表“否认做过某事”

The procession is older than anyone remembers, and **the town charter** still names the three families whose job it is to carry the plaster saint down to the water. This year the council appointed Ruth, which pleased her more than she was willing to admit. Four men from the fish market came at noon to elevate the statue onto the back of a flatbed truck. The flagpole mechanism on the pier had seized, so **a temporary crank** was fitted by a man who called the era of iron boats a waste of paint. A section of the railing was roped off, and nobody argued about the necessity of it. **The gravity of the occasion** made everyone speak in low voices, even the children who did not understand it.

> **the town charter** 镇上的特许状 charter 指授予城镇、机构权利与义务的正式文件；与 constitution（宪法）不同，charter 多用于地方或公司
>
> **a temporary crank** 一个临时的曲柄 temporary 指“临时代用的”，与 permanent 相对；修饰物件时强调替代方案，不暗示质量差
>
> **The gravity of the occasion** 这一场合的庄重 gravity 在此指“严肃、庄重”而非“重力”；常与 realize / understand 连用，of 后接场合或局势

By Thursday the town smelled of vinegar and dye, because every flag for the procession had to be dipped by hand in the shed behind the fish market. The rooms of the motel stand **in a linear row** along the shore, which is why the superior ones at the far end sell last. Ruth had ordered three tins of red dye and received one, and the scarcity turned a simple job into a complex argument about which flags could go without. She **paid compensation to** a commercial photographer who had booked the front rooms for a shoot, and the loss meant the week would not **exceed last year's takings**. Her bookkeeping stayed consistent, and the export crates of salted fish went out on Friday as usual.

> **in a linear row** 排成一条直线 linear 指“沿一条线的、直线的”，常修饰 row / sequence / order；与 parallel 不同，后者指并行不相交
>
> **paid compensation to** 向……支付赔偿 compensation 不可数，表“赔偿金”时用 pay compensation to sb for sth；compensate 才是动词
>
> **exceed last year's takings** 超过去年的营业额 exceed 后直接接被超过的数量或标准，不加 than；takings 用复数指营业收入的总额

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> **seemed to convey** 似乎传达出 convey 指传达意思、情感或信息，常用 convey sth to sb；不用于“运送货物”以外的抽象物时要搭 meaning / sense
> **the ultimate decision** 最终的决定 ultimate 表“最终的”，只放在名词前作定语，不能作表语说 the decision is ultimate
> **compel the council to** 迫使议会去…… compel sb to do sth 是固定句型，语气比 force 正式；不用于 compel doing

## 译文

我姑妈露丝是在我十一岁那年春天买下“海裂”汽车旅馆的，因为价钱很低，而风景并不怎么样。房子就立在路一直伸进潮水的地方，所以海水一天两次涨到桩子底下。一半房间有湿木头和缓慢腐坏的气味，门边的铜号码已经泛绿。露丝说四号房顶上那块褐斑会淡下去，可我看它像是永久的。办公室门上方有个小小的传感器，一个普通的下午会响六次。她说这六辆车属于她那些忠实的客人，而蓝本子里的预算答应她，到旺季每晚能有四十辆。窗台上那只玻璃浮球，是她买得起的唯一装饰。

每天早上露丝都从收音机里背下潮汐表，把时间写在手腕上。天气预报员能提前四小时预测一场狂风，周二那天他预告傍晚就到。露丝做了通常的预防措施：办公室门口堆沙袋，把浮球挪到更高处。港务处的一个年轻人过来通知她，节日的帐篷要改搭在硬质地面上。我试着偷听他们谈钱的事，可露丝的脾气藏不住，嗓门却收得住。不过她容忍我提问，而且真诚得让别的大人去看自己的鞋尖。她没有否认自己在担心，六点刚过不久，雨就横着来了。

这场游行比任何人记得的都要古老，镇上的特许状至今写明，哪三户人家负责把石膏圣徒像抬到水边。今年议事会指派了露丝，她高兴的程度超过了她愿意承认的。鱼市来的四个男人中午过来，把圣像抬上一辆平板卡车的后斗。码头上的旗杆装置早就锈死了，于是一个认定铁船时代纯属浪费油漆的男人，装了个临时的曲柄。栏杆有一段被绳子拦了起来，没有人质疑这有什么必要。场合的庄重让所有人都压低了声音，连不懂事的孩子也一样。

到了星期四，全镇都是醋和染料的气味，因为游行用的每一面旗都得在鱼市后面的棚子里手工浸染。旅馆的房间沿着海岸排成一条直线，所以最里头那些高级房总是最后才卖出去。露丝订了三罐红染料，只收到一罐，这点短缺把一件简单的活变成了一场复杂的争论：哪些旗可以不用。她向一位预订了前排房间拍摄的商业摄影师支付了赔偿，这笔损失意味着这一周的收入超不过去年。她的账目倒是始终一致，腌鱼的出口货柜星期五照常发走。

星期六，柜台上的报纸登着一条标题：两名镇外的恐怖分子被捕；到九点已有三位客人问游行还安不安全。露丝害怕的时候反而机智，于是她说，一个计划不周的人会觉得我们这些旗是全郡最不划算的目标。我渴得笑不出来，也没能从她声音里察觉出一点恐惧，我想这正是她的意图。她短短几句话似乎传达的比字面更多，最终的决定是照常举行。码头上的人越聚越多，多到足以迫使议事会重新开放那段栏杆。八月的最后一周收入又往下走了，可那六位老客人的忠诚还在。